

R&I Conference Call for Participation

Title

Inverting Expertise in User Experience Design

Session Organizers

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Abstract

As a field of study, User Experience (UX) represents a broad range of human interactions with interfaces and digital media technologies. As such, UX imposes no limit on the possible experiences that users can have when interacting with technology. Nevertheless, UX as a discipline tends towards delineating specific design principles and scientific models that treat the practice of designing for users and their experiences as a matter of formal expertise. In this Participatory Session, we investigate methods for analyzing and confronting this expert approach to UX. Participants are prompted to analyze existing popular interfaces – such as those of Google, Twitter, and Amazon – and identify the purposes, agents, and qualities of their user experiences. Participants then form groups to produce mockups of inverted interfaces that invert the qualities and values of the user experiences that they have analyzed. Through this inversion, seamless searches on Google might become queries that expose the prioritization of search results, or seamless shopping on Amazon is inverted to prompt customers to buy scrupulously. In the discussion that follows, the inverted interfaces are analyzed as speculative designs of user experience. As a group, we examine how the inverted interfaces reveal inconspicuous qualities of existing user experiences, how inverting these qualities challenges their normativity, and how speculative interfaces can formulate alternatives to expert approaches to UX.

Call for Participation Instructions

Participants will be provided with materials to work with. Optionally, participants are encouraged to bring computers with photo editing software, but this is not required.